

**When it comes to good looks, in the Lifestyle category, Apple notebooks lead the pack**



Wipro Little Genius CP

due to the faster processor and the 512 MB of RAM. Similar results were seen in the video encoding test. The MSI M510C wasn't far behind the Acer in all these tests, and even beat it in the display, battery life and wireless tests.

The screen quality on the MSI was better than that on the Acer in all the parameters that we laid down. The Toshiba Tecra, the IBM R50 and the Zenith Director have better displays than most.

The MSI M510C also had the longest battery-life, and hence took a good lead over the Acer, which sacrifices battery life for performance. The Compaq V1040AP came had the second-longest battery life, and was followed by the Zenith Director.

Despite its 802.11g Wireless adapter, the Acer notebook failed to return the expected scores—even after repeated attempts. The MSI, on the other hand, did extremely well, and we could stream a movie on the wireless link—it played without a jerk. Wipro's Little Genius CP also came out with flying colours in the wireless tests.

### Conclusion

Considering scores on performance, features, usability and price, the MSI M510C emerges as the winner—it gets the Best Buy Gold award. Wipro's Little genius won the Best Buy Silver award, because of its all-round abilities.

However, you shouldn't ignore products such as the IBM R50, Toshiba Tecra, Compaq V1040AP or Acer 8005LMi. The only reason they lose out is the price; but then again, the designs they sport, the features they offer, the name of a trusted brand, etc., come at a premium.

### LIFESTYLE COMPANIONS

Notebooks that blend looks, appeal, style and functionality fall into the Lifestyle category. These products reflect the personality of the user, and may have the latest technology or just look elegant and sophisticated. These products are meant for a buyer who wants to stand out in a crowd.

The category consisted of nine notebooks from Samsung, LG, Compaq and Toshiba; all cost above Rs 1 lakh.

### Features

Fancy features were the norm here. Samsung offers an inbuilt biometric security solution with their laptops. Samsung P30 and X10 models have in-built biometric security solution.

LG's LS40 is rated to provide 10 hours of battery life. However, it provided just four hours in our test.

Compaq's X1237AP was the most feature-rich laptop, offering a Bluetooth adapter, DVD-Writer, and 15.4-inch wide format screen—truly useful features as compared to other fancy stuff provided by others.

Every notebook in this category was based on the new Centrino platform. The processors were mostly Pentium M running at either 1.5 GHz or 1.4 GHz. Samsung's X05 was the only exception—it had a Celeron M processor.

The Toshiba Satellite M30 comes with a breathtaking 15.4-inch wide display that is crystal clear. The sheer brilliance of this screen, combined with the Harmon Kardon speakers, takes multimedia to an unmatched level.

Barring Samsung's X10 and X05, the others supported either of the two legacy ports—serial

## Lapples Anyone?

**N**otebooks that give you a feeling of being different, notebooks that will have people look at you with wonder; yes, we're talking Apple here. Notebooks or desktops, Apple computers are always desirable. The iBooks and PowerBooks have a charm of their own.

Apple leads the pack when it comes to meticulous details on the appearance. Minute details such as rubber padding on the top lid for better grip, a LED in the power socket that changes colour to indicate battery charging, retracting latches that hold the upper lid, etc., are enthralling.

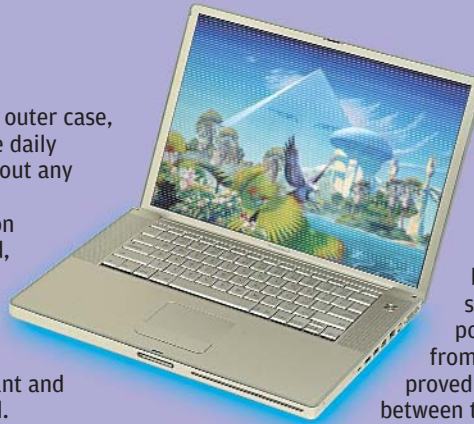
For the comparison, we got one 12-inch iBook and three PowerBooks in the increasing size of their display—12, 15 and 17 inches. The essential difference between the two classes of Apple notebooks is self-explanatory, the PowerBook as the name suggest are powerful and are priced higher, whereas the iBooks are slightly low on power, features and price.

The milky white 12-inch iBook has a

polycarbonate outer case, which can take daily thrashing without any problems. The PowerBooks, on the other hand, offer a brush finished Aluminium casing that is scratch-resistant and looks beautiful.

The PowerBooks offer a Superdrive that is capable of burning DVD's, Gigabit Ethernet ports, a Firewire 800 port that is capable of nearly double the data transfer rate of a standard Firewire port, inbuilt Bluetooth, a 54 Mbps WiFi adapter, and the latest in graphics—ATI's Mobility Radeon 9700.

Apple's Mac OSX Panther is the OS used in all the notebooks, and is simple to use and understand. Mac OSX comes with all the necessary applications, such as an e-mail client, a PIM software and Web browsers. Microsoft's new Office



2004 for the Mac platform takes care of the Word processing and spreadsheet needs.

G4-based notebooks are slightly slower than Centrino-powered notebooks from other brands, as proved from the comparison between the Dell D800 and 17-inch PowerBook—we ran the

PSbench action script on Adobe Photoshop CS. Dell's D800 took 195 seconds to complete the script, whereas the 17-inch Apple took around 305 seconds for the same task.

However, it's not the performance that matters here; it's the user experience that is the driving force. Our stints with these notebooks convinced us that they are simply the best. Migrating from the Windows platform does pose some problems initially, but the simple Mac OSX interface can be grasped easily.